clergymen. Harold Macmillan, on the other hand, was an avid fan of Trollope, and no doubt drew inspiration from the often-devious machinations of his characters.

Gilding golden bridges?

The suggestion that this ‘brilliant diplomatic manoeuvre’ side-stepped the Turkish Jupiters en route to the golden bridge became an accepted part of the story. Several decades after the crisis, however, it became clear the dominant narrative was misleading. The Turkish Jupiters *were* involved. On the evening of 27 October, the President despatched his brother to hand his written reply to Khrushchev’s letter of 26 October. RFK was also tasked with delivering an oral message to Dobrynin. This presented Moscow with a formula that would remove the missiles from Turkey (and Italy). Key to the formula was that it must remain secret, including from America’s NATO allies. As Sheldon Stern has emphatically demonstrated, the Trollope Ploy was ‘a myth’.[51] With the revelations about a secret deal over the Turkish Jupiters, Anthony Trollope found his way back to the fiction section.

One of the more striking features of the ExComm discussions during Saturday, 27 October was President Kennedy’s willingness to consider a deal involving the Turkish missiles. He had told David Ormsby-Gore on 21 October that the missiles were militarily useless, and he would do a deal if the politics were right. Some of his advisers – McNamara and McCone – had come to accept this was necessary. Most of ExComm, including the custodians of NATO solidarity, remained opposed. Agreement to remove the Turkish missiles would mean sacrificing the interests of Washington’s NATO allies to preserve US interests in the Caribbean. Kennedy had long seen the missiles in Turkey as obsolete, vulnerable, and destabilising. Before the crisis, he would have withdrawn them had it not been for the Turkish government, which, for its own political reasons, wanted to keep them.

The British were kept abreast of developments in Washington, including the various proposals from Khrushchev (though not, it seems, the Scali-Feklisov channel). Kennedy emphasised to Macmillan that the US should